

PHIL 5: Contemporary Moral Problems (30380)
Department of Philosophy
University of California, Irvine

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Office Hours/Live Discussion: Thursdays 11:00-12:00pm; office hours by appointment

Link: <https://uci.zoom.us/j/5571936797>

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Office Hours: by appointment

Course Description: This online course will introduce you to a series of moral problems as they are discussed in contemporary philosophy. We will explore the metaethical and normative foundations for our moral claims. We will also discuss some issues in contemporary philosophy that are particularly salient: ethics in artificial intelligence, freedom of speech in the digital age, and how our democratic institutions relate to these lines of inquiry. There will be some difficult or dense readings; I will supplement these readings with shorter essays and video uploads. I will host live discussion sessions every Thursday from 11:00-12:00pm, feel free to ask any questions you have about the course material then. Likewise, if that time does not work, we can always schedule a Zoom meeting at another time. You will have two basic types of assignments in this course. A weekly discussion post (roughly 250 words in length) wherein you critically interrogate a conceptual claim in one of the readings; please refrain from using AI to do this assignment, as this is an opportunity for you to sow the seeds of a potential essay topic and defeats the purpose of the assignment. You will also have two short essays, roughly 1,000-1,500 words in length. You will have all the resources available for the essay in the course Canvas website. If you wish to use extra sources, please contact either me or your TA for approval; failure to do so will result in a significant grade drop.

Week 1: Foundations: Metaethics and Moral Objectivity

Guiding Questions:

- *Are moral claims objectively true or just expressions of emotion?*
- *What does it mean to say something is “right” or “wrong”?*

Core Readings:

- J.L. Mackie, *The Subjectivity of Values*
<https://wmit-pages-prod.s3.amazonaws.com/wp-content/uploads/sites/283/2022/06/16133854/mackie.pdf>
- David Enoch, *Why I Am an Objectivist About Ethics (And Why You Are Too)*
<https://r.jordan.im/download/philosophy/David%20Enoch%20-%20Why%20I%20am%20an%20Objectivist%20about%20Ethics.pdf>

Supplemental Material:

- <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/moral-realism/>
- <https://1000wordphilosophy.com/2014/04/14/moral-error-theory/>
- <https://1000wordphilosophy.com/2015/11/05/ethical-realism/>
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=N7_a2CXRCTI

Week 2: AI, Ethics, and the Moral Status of Machines

Guiding Questions:

- *Can AI systems be moral agents or moral patients?*
- *What ethical limits should apply to AI development and deployment?*
- *How should we think about bias, surveillance, and automation?*

Core Readings:

- <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ethics-ai/> (read section 2 in particular “Main Debates”)
- <https://iep.utm.edu/ethics-of-artificial-intelligence/> (Read “Main Debates” section)
- <https://1000wordphilosophy.com/2024/10/03/ai-ethics/>
- <https://1000wordphilosophy.com/2024/02/13/artificial-intelligence/>

Week 3: Free Speech and Its Moral Limits

Guiding Questions:

- *Are there limits to free speech in a moral or democratic society?*
- *What’s the relationship between speech, harm, and responsibility?*
- *Should hate speech be protected?*

Core Readings:

- John Stuart Mill, *On Liberty* (ch. 2: Of the Liberty of Thought and Discussion) <https://www.utilitarianism.com/ol/two.html>
- Jeremy Waldron, *The Harm in Hate Speech* (Intro + Ch. 1) <https://danielwharris.com/teaching/394/Waldron.pdf>
- <https://1000wordphilosophy.com/2021/02/04/free-speech/>

Week 4: Applying Normative Theories: Moral Frameworks in Action

Guiding Questions:

- *How do consequentialism, deontology, and virtue ethics approach real-world problems?*
- *What do these frameworks assume about human nature and moral reasoning?*

Core Readings:

- Rosalind Hursthouse, *Virtue Theory and Abortion* (Virtue Ethics)
<https://www.jstor.org/stable/pdf/2265432.pdf>
- Peter Singer, *Famine, Affluence, and Morality* (Utilitarianism)
<https://utilitarianism.net/peter-singer-famine-affluence-and-morality/>
- Immanuel Kant, *Groundwork* (selections on the categorical imperative, Deontology)
<https://www.earlymoderntexts.com/assets/pdfs/kant1785.pdf>

Supplemental Readings:

- <https://1000wordphilosophy.com/2022/02/06/virtue-ethics/>
- <https://1000wordphilosophy.com/2014/05/15/consequentialism/>
- <https://1000wordphilosophy.com/2014/06/09/kantian-ethics/>

Week 5: Misinformation, Democracy, and Epistemic Responsibility

Guiding Questions:

- *Do we have a moral duty to believe responsibly?*
- *Is spreading misinformation a moral harm?*
- *What role do platforms, governments, or individuals have in curbing misinformation?*

Core Readings:

- C. Thi Nguyen, *Echo Chambers and Epistemic Bubbles*
<https://philpapers.org/archive/NGUECA.pdf>
- Neil Levy, *In Trust We Trust: Epistemic Vigilance and Responsibility*
<https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/02691728.2022.2042420#abstract>

Supplemental Readings:

- <https://repository.law.umich.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1047&context=mtlr>
- <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/ethics-social-networking/>

Course Requirements:

Short written assignment | Due: Every Sunday, by 11:59pm PST: 20%

A weekly written assignment wherein you critically evaluate the contents of the week prior; these discussion posts should be ~250 words in length, they should be your words alone (no generative AI use please). A Critical evaluation could be a critique of a philosophical position, a defense of a position, or even a distinction if you think a concept that has been discussed is not sufficiently clear.

Short Essays: 80%

You will be required to draft two short essays in the course, roughly 1,000 to 1,500 words in length. Prompts will be provided for each essay. Essays can be completed using the material from the course, likewise, you are more than welcome to include external sources, although they need to be approved by either myself or your TA. (First essay due August 22th) (Second Essay Due September 5th)

Late Policy: Any request for an extension must be made 48 hours prior to the due date/time via an email. Half a letter grade will be deducted for each day that the assignment is late from the date it's due.

Academic Honesty: Academic misconduct, in its most basic form, is gaining or attempting to gain a grade, degree, or other academic accomplishment by any means other than through your own work. The formal policy states, "No student shall engage in any activity that involves attempting to receive a grade by means other than honest effort and shall not aid another student who is attempting to do so." Reproducing work submitted in other classes, even if it is authored by the student, is also plagiarism. For more information, please view UCI's Academic Integrity Policy and Procedures.

Class Withdrawal Policy: It is the student's responsibility to officially drop/withdraw from any courses before the deadline posted by the university's registrar's office. Please refer to UCI's academic calendar <http://www.reg.uci.edu/enrollment/withdrawals/> for the withdrawal policy, procedure, and refunded schedule.

Disability Statement: The University of California, Irvine, is committed to providing a barrier-free environment for learning and an electronic environment that is accessible to everyone, including individuals with disabilities. Students with disabilities who believe they may need accommodations in this class are encouraged to contact the Disability Services Center at <https://dsc.uci.edu/> or by phone at 949- 824-7494 as soon as possible to better ensure that such accommodations are implemented in a timely fashion.

Technical Support: Contact the OIT helpdesk at oit@uci.edu or call (949) 824-2222 for all technical support and training needs.